to go for jobs. Add to this the other all-pervasive fact: affordable internet, smartphones, better exposure. From just 8 million internet users in 2014, Bihar registered a massive rise to 39.3 million by September 2020. "This has given newer opportunities to girls to interact and make friends even from home. The older caste and religious divides are still resilient, but the young are showing a new willingness to pull down the barriers. Elopement, though, is often their solitary option," says Patna High Court lawyer Sanjeev Kumar. Dr Madhavi sees it as the expression of a change that cannot be controlled. "It's inevitable. Many cases can be impulsive in nature, but girls decide based on what they think is the best course available. I believe it is time for the parents to behave maturely, and let their daughters trust and communicate freely with them."

Some indeed do. It happened for Easha. She and Smit married in a Bhagalpur temple, and had to spend just a day on the run. They approached Smit's parents first, who agreed to accept them. A week on, Easha's parents too landed—and shed their initial reluctance, which owed only to the fact that Smit, a graduate with an additional degree in Japanese, is still only looking for a job. Easha teaches at a private school in Bhagalpur. More importantly, the couple is happy. In Dr Madhavi's lens, this is a sign of the *parents*, as a generic group, maturing.

THE STATISTICS: BLACK, WHITE

Sadly, signs are that an overwhelming majority of parents/families are yet to attain that stage. NCRB data shows 170 killings over love affairs in 2020; 174 in 2021. That's almost one murder over love affairs every two days. (This is distinct from murders over illicit relationships, so a majority are believed to be cases of familial revenge.) Bihar figures among the three worst Indian states on this front, accounting for over 11 per cent of all such murders.

The sheer deluge of love may even be provoking this counter-violence. The Bihar police maintains a separate record where it has bracketed as many as 2,571 'abduction for marriage' cases prima facie as consensual elopements—just in the first eight months of 2022. That means, on an average, 11 runaway couples every day in Bihar. The number for all of 2020 was just 2,817. That's a 37 per cent spike. In fact, lovers eloping account for 31 per cent of *all* abduction cases registered in 2022. If we add the 3,556 cases registered as abductions for marriage (where the police is less sure about it being consensual), the number goes up to 6,227. That takes such cases to 77 per cent of all abduction cases recorded in Bihar in 2022.

The NCRB does not segregate this data, says a top police officer in Patna, despite an awareness on the ground. Patna-based lawyer K.D. Mishra seconds that and explains the legal grey areas: "All FIRs end up with Section 366 of the IPC being slapped against the accused, relating to abducting or inducing women for marriage, making every elopement technically a crime." So, in a scenario where educated women are making a choice, and the Nitish Kumar regime offers a Rs 1 lakh grant to inter-caste couples, it's cast as a negative. Says Prof. Gyanendra Yadav, who teaches sociology at Patliputra University in Patna, "Girl's families tend to look at romance, especially inter-caste, as a blot on their social prestige. Thus, it even spurs them into violence."

Rahul Kumar alias Chhotu, a 22-year-old DJ service provider in Patna, has become one of the latest victims of that intolerance. With Covid restrictions gone, he was hoping to net in some good business this marriage season—he postponed his own elopement plans with his girlfriend by a month. December 7 was to be their big day: the couple had planned to register their marriage and then elope, only to return after getting their marriage certificate in the new year. But Vikash, his girlfriend's brother, got wind of the plan. On November 6, Vikash and his gang thrashed Chhotu mercilessly. Next day, he succumbed to his injuries in a hospital. Chhotu's mother Pinki Devi is unable to come to grips with the tragedy. But even in her grief, she voices sentiments one wishes more parents could emulate. "We would have accepted my son marrying any girl of his choice. Who will give us justice now?" she asks, sobbing incessantly.

It's a pattern that repeats endlessly. On October 30, Ayan was thrashed to death in Muzaffarpur while meeting his girlfriend at a river bank during Chhath. In July, Chhotu Yadav was killed by his girlfriend Arati's family. In June, 26-year-old Monu Rai was shot dead by wife Purnima's father Sunil Pathak and brother Prabhat, a year after they had eloped and married. They had only returned recently, hoping things would have settled down. It was not to be. They became martyrs in a new war between generations in Bihar, where the undeterred youth are thumbing their nose at the old world—even if they have to go AWOL. ■

BREAKOUT COUPLES

- Bihar has registered a sharp rise in elopement cases. Police records suggest that there's been a 36 per cent spike in elopement marriages in 2022, over the figures for 2020
- Almost all elopement cases have IPC 366 slapped against the boy by the girl's family, which technically qualifies them as cases of abductions. The police are dutybound to investigate those, so couples often post videos online to prove it's consensual
- If the runaway couples try to win acceptance from their families, it is at their own peril. NCRB data for 2020 shows 170 killings over love affairs; in 2021, the number was 174